

THE NUTRITION CLUB CLINIC

# Healthy Weight Gain Guide

Practical nutrition guidance for gaining weight steadily and healthily.

Individual needs vary with medical history, activity and appetite.

## What's inside

Gaining weight can be just as difficult as losing it, and the aim is not simply a higher number on the scale — it is more muscle and healthy tissue, not just fat. This guide covers how to rule out medical causes, how to calculate what you actually need, and how to eat enough when your appetite is small.

1. First, rule out the causes
2. Your numbers: calories and protein
3. Calorie-dense foods that still nourish
4. Eating enough when your appetite is small
5. Training, tracking and staying on course

### How to use this guide

Start with section 2 to set your calorie and protein targets, then use the food and meal ideas in sections 3 and 4. Weigh yourself weekly under the same conditions and adjust every fortnight rather than every day.

## 1. First, rule out the causes

Before adding calories, it is worth understanding why weight is low. Sometimes the answer is simply a high metabolism and a small appetite; sometimes something else is driving it.

- **Thyroid overactivity** — weight loss with a fast heartbeat, heat intolerance, anxiety.
- **Undiagnosed diabetes** — weight loss with thirst, frequent urination, fatigue.
- **Coeliac disease or other malabsorption** — bloating, diarrhoea, deficiencies.
- **Inflammatory bowel disease, infections, chronic illness or cancer.**
- **Depression, anxiety, grief or high stress** — all suppress appetite.
- **Eating disorders** — these need specialist care, and this guide is not a substitute for it.
- **Medicines** — stimulants, some antibiotics and chemotherapy blunt appetite.

### See a doctor first if

you have lost weight without trying, especially more than 5% of your body weight in 6–12 months, or if weight loss comes with fever, night sweats, blood in stool, pain, persistent vomiting or extreme fatigue.

### What healthy gain looks like

A realistic rate is **0.25–0.5 kg per week**. Faster gain tends to be mostly fat, and can worsen cholesterol and blood sugar. Slow gain paired with resistance training puts a far higher share of the gain into muscle.

## 2. Your numbers: calories and protein

### Step 1 — estimate maintenance calories

A quick estimate: multiply your body weight in kilograms by 30–35 if you are lightly active, or 35–40 if you are very active. A 55 kg moderately active person lands around 1,900–2,100 kcal.

### Step 2 — add a surplus

Add **300–500 kcal** per day for steady gain. Adding 1,000+ kcal overnight usually backfires: it kills appetite and adds mostly fat. Start at +300 and increase if the scale hasn't moved after two weeks.

### Step 3 — set protein and the rest

| Nutrient     | Target                       | Why                                                                         |
|--------------|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Protein      | 1.6–2.2 g per kg body weight | Supplies the raw material for muscle; anything more adds little             |
| Carbohydrate | 45–55% of calories           | Fuels training and spares protein; the easiest lever for adding calories    |
| Fat          | 25–35% of calories           | Most calorie-dense nutrient — the simplest way to add energy without volume |
| Fluid        | Mostly between meals         | Drinking with meals fills you up before you finish eating                   |

#### Worked example

A 55 kg person, moderately active: maintenance  $\approx$  1,950 kcal. Target  $\approx$  2,350 kcal with about 100 g protein, 290 g carbohydrate and 80 g fat. That is roughly three meals of 600 kcal plus two snacks of 275 kcal.

### 3. Calorie-dense foods that still nourish

The trick is more energy in less volume. These foods let you hit your target without feeling uncomfortably full.

| Category          | Best choices                                                                                             |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Fats (most dense) | Olive oil, ghee and butter, nut butters, tahini, avocado, coconut milk, cheese, seeds                    |
| Protein           | Eggs, full-fat milk and yoghurt, paneer, chicken thigh, oily fish, lentils, beans, tofu, minced meat     |
| Carbohydrate      | Rice, potatoes, pasta, bread, oats, roti, dried fruit, granola, bananas, honey                           |
| Drinks that count | Whole milk, milkshakes, smoothies with yoghurt and nut butter, lassi, fruit-and-oat blends               |
| Easy add-ons      | A spoon of olive oil over cooked food, grated cheese, cream in soup, powdered milk stirred into porridge |

#### Cheap, high-calorie staples

Peanut butter, whole milk powder, eggs, bananas, oats, lentils, potatoes, rice, seasonal nuts and dates deliver a lot of energy per rupee.

##### What to avoid

Gaining weight on chips, fizzy drinks, biscuits and fast food will raise your weight and your triglycerides, blood pressure and liver fat along with it. The aim is nutrient-dense calories, not junk-dense ones. Treats can exist — just not as the strategy.

## 4. Eating enough when your appetite is small

- 1 **Eat by the clock, not by hunger.** Five or six eating occasions every 2–3 hours. If you wait to feel hungry you will fall short.
- 2 **Never drink water or tea right before or during meals.** Fluid displaces food; keep drinks for 30 minutes after eating — or make the drink itself calorific.
- 3 **Eat the dense part first.** Start with the meat, rice or fat-rich part of the plate while your appetite is strongest; salad and soup last.
- 4 **Enrich, don't enlarge.** Adding a spoon of oil, cheese or nut butter to a normal-sized portion adds 100–200 kcal without more volume.
- 5 **Drink your calories.** A smoothie of whole milk, banana, oats, peanut butter and yoghurt can deliver 600–700 kcal and is far easier than a fourth meal.
- 6 **Keep a bedtime snack.** Milk with dates and nuts, or yoghurt with granola, adds a whole eating occasion painlessly.
- 7 **Cook in batches.** Low appetite plus an empty fridge equals a missed meal. Keep ready snacks within arm's reach: nuts, cheese, boiled eggs, dried fruit.

### Sample high-calorie day ( $\approx$ 2,600 kcal)

**Breakfast:** 3-egg omelette with cheese, two slices of buttered toast, glass of whole milk. **Mid-morning:** Banana and peanut butter smoothie. **Lunch:** Rice with chicken curry cooked in ghee, yoghurt, salad. **Afternoon:** Handful of nuts and dates with tea. **Dinner:** Pasta with olive oil, minced meat and cheese. **Bedtime:** Milk with honey and almonds.

## 5. Training, tracking and staying on course

### Lift weights — this decides where the weight goes

- Resistance training 3–4 times a week, focusing on compound movements: squats, deadlifts, presses, rows, pull-ups. Bodyweight and bands work if you have no gym.
- Progressive overload: add a little weight or a rep most weeks. Without progression the surplus becomes fat.
- Keep cardio moderate — some is good for health and appetite, but hours of it burns the surplus you are working to create.
- Sleep 7–9 hours. Muscle is built during recovery, not during the session.
- Spread protein across the day, roughly 25–40 g per meal, including something after training.

### Tracking

Weigh yourself 1–2 times a week, in the morning after the bathroom, before eating. Compare weekly averages, not single days — daily swings of 1–2 kg are just water and food. Also track how clothes fit, arm and chest measurements, and how your lifts are progressing.

### Troubleshooting

| Problem                       | Fix                                                                                               |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| No gain after 2–3 weeks       | Add another 250–300 kcal, usually as a liquid snack; check you're eating on non-training days too |
| Gaining too fast or softening | Reduce the surplus to +200 kcal and add one extra resistance session                              |
| Too full to finish meals      | Switch some food to liquid calories; reduce raw vegetable volume; add fats rather than bulk       |
| Progress stalls after months  | Recalculate your needs at the new body weight — maintenance rises as you gain                     |

#### Be patient with the timeline

Realistic natural muscle gain is roughly 0.25–0.5 kg per month for most people, faster for beginners. Six months of consistency produces a visible change; two weeks does not.

## Important note

This guide is general nutrition education only. It is not medical advice, a diagnosis, or a treatment plan, and it cannot account for your personal history, laboratory results, allergies or medicines. Always speak to your doctor, dietitian or pharmacist before making significant changes to your diet, supplements or activity — especially if you are pregnant or breastfeeding, have kidney, liver or heart disease, an eating disorder, or take prescription medication. If you experience severe or sudden symptoms, seek urgent medical care. Unintentional weight loss or an inability to gain weight can signal an underlying condition and should always be assessed by a doctor first.

### Questions or want a personalised plan?

This guide covers general principles. A one-to-one consultation with The Nutrition Club Clinic lets us tailor portions, meal timing, food preferences, budget and any medications or conditions to you.

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